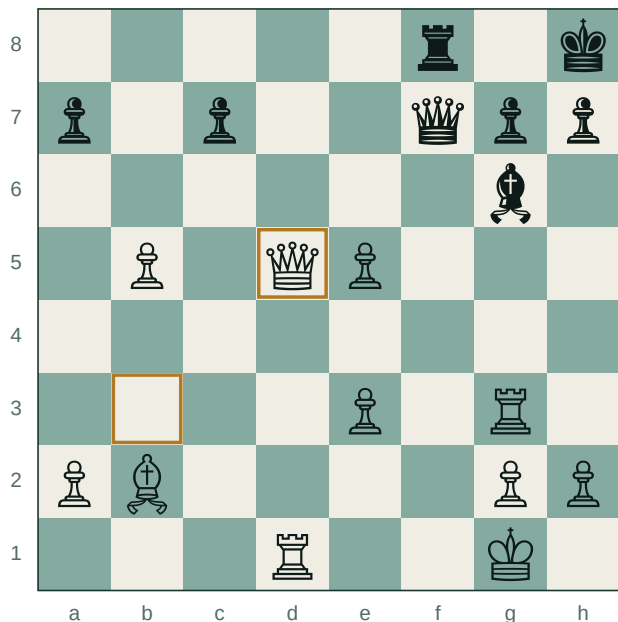


Mate in three: Black, move 26

Mate in three

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Qxd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Qf2+ 27. Kh1 Qf1+ 28. Rxf1 Rxf1#

26...Qf2+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f2 it attacks king on g1, rook on g3 and bishop on b2. Recorded reply: **27.Kh1**.

27...Qf1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on d1. Recorded reply: **28.Rxf1**.

28...Rxf1# Mate: rook on f1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on b2. Check for tactical protection.